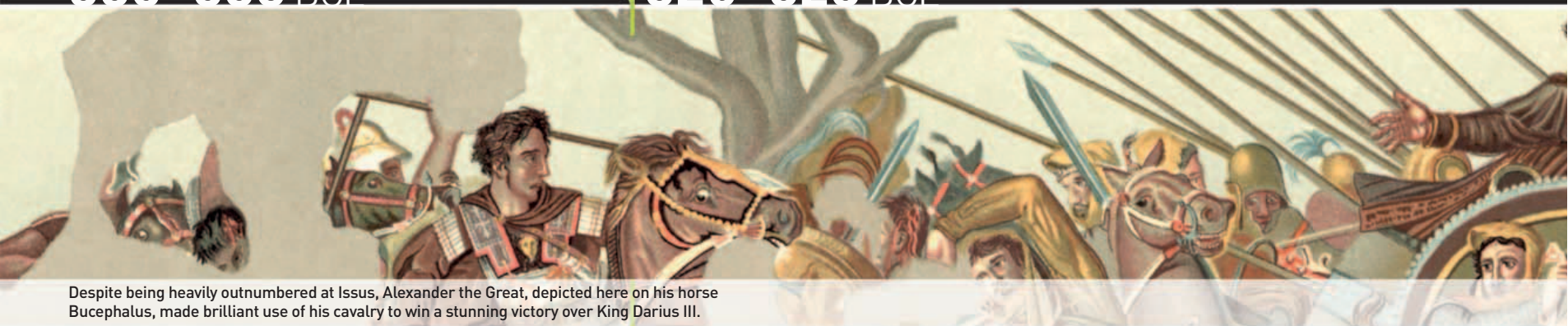




Despite being heavily outnumbered at Issus, Alexander the Great, depicted here on his horse Bucephalus, made brilliant use of his cavalry to win a stunning victory over King Darius III.



AFTER THE ASSASSINATION OF PHILIP OF MACEDONIA

in 336 BCE (see 355–337 BCE), his 20-year-old son Alexander (often referred to as Alexander the Great) became commander of the major Greek city states. The next year Alexander invaded Thrace, but a rumor that he had been killed caused a major revolt centered on the Greek city of Thebes, supported by **Darius III of Persia** (r. 336–330 BCE). Alexander reacted swiftly; the Thebans were defeated and their city razed. The other states soon submitted. In 334 BCE, Alexander hurried to Anatolia, where a Macedonian army was already established, totaling perhaps 43,000 infantry and 6,000 cavalry. Although this figure was dwarfed by the forces of the local Persian satraps (governors), Alexander's cavalry smashed the lines of the **satrap Arsites** at the Granicus River in northwest Turkey. He pushed on toward the heart of the Persian Empire. In 333 BCE, at Issus, northern Syria, he routed an army

Ruins of Persepolis

The Persian ceremonial capital of Persepolis was burned to the ground by Alexander's troops in 330 BCE.

led by Darius III himself. In 331 BCE, the Macedonians defeated Darius III again at **Gaugamela** (in modern Iraq). The next year Darius was stabbed to death by **Bessus**, one of his generals. Alexander now seemed to have acquired the whole of the vast Persian Empire.



Aristotle

The philosopher Aristotle was employed by Philip of Macedonia as Alexander the Great's tutor.

AFTER HIS MURDER OF DARIUS, Bessus declared himself the new king of Persia (as **Artaxerxes V**), but some of the Persian satraps submitted to Alexander instead of Bessus. During 330–329 BCE, Alexander pursued Bessus into the easternmost regions of the Persian Empire, beyond the Hindu Kush and into Bactria. Finally, in Sogdiana, north of the Oxus River, the local nobles, led by the Sogdian warlord **Spitamenes**, betrayed Bessus and handed him over to Alexander. Once Alexander had continued his march north, however, Spitamenes revolted. It took Alexander a year of bitter campaigning to relieve the **siege**

Alexander the Great's conquests Alexander penetrated the farthest corners of the Persian empire. To cement his rule, he founded a series of new cities, almost all named after himself, notably Alexandria in Egypt.

CONQUEST OF ALEXANDER

- Macedonian Empire 336–323 BCE
- Route taken by Alexander's forces



of **Macaranda** (Samarkand) and pacify Sogdiana, although the fortress of the "Sogdian Rock" managed to hold out against the Macedonian forces until 327 BCE. Alexander then crossed into the Kabul Valley, and the following year, at the Hydaspes River, he overcame the local ruler **Porus**. His plans to push further into India were stymied by his soldiers who, demoralized and disease-ridden, mutinied and demanded to go home. Part of the army returned home by sea under Nearchus, but a detachment under Alexander marched through the harsh Gedrosian desert, suffering heavy losses. His army reached central Persia early in 324 BCE, but Alexander, still planning new expeditions into Arabia, died of a fever at Babylon in May 323 BCE, at age 33.

In central Italy, the Samnites of the central-southern Apennines, who had lost a war against the Romans in 342–340 BCE, fought them once more in the **Second Samnite War** (326–304 BCE). The

30 THE AGE OF ALEXANDER'S FAVORITE HORSE, BUCEPHALUS, WHEN IT DIED

advance of the Romans into Campania after their abolition of the **Latin League** in 338 BCE alarmed the Samnites, and the Roman placing of a colony in their land in 328 BCE and tensions over the control of Neapolis (Naples) led to the **outbreak of war** in 326 BCE. In 321 BCE, the Samnites defeated a Roman army at the Caudine Forks. The **Romans were humiliated** by being forced to bow down and "pass under the yoke" (an arch made from their captured spears). Four years of peace followed before the Romans renewed the war and, despite dogged resistance by the Samnites, finally emerged victorious in 304 BCE.

336 BCE Philip of Macedonia murdered; he is succeeded by his son Alexander

335 BCE Philosopher Aristotle founds a school in Athens

334 BCE Alexander defeats Persians at the Granicus River

332 BCE Zeno of Cyprus founds the Stoic school of philosophers in Athens

330 BCE Alexander's army pillages Persepolis

331 BCE Persians defeated by Alexander at Battle of Gaugamela

330 BCE Darius III assassinated by the rebel satrap Bessus

328 BCE Murder of Cleitus the Black, joint commander of Alexander's Companion Cavalry

327–327 BCE Alexander conquers Bactria and Sogdiana

327 BCE Romans become involved in a dispute with the Samnites over control of the Greek city of Neapolis

326 BCE Alexander seriously wounded during the siege of the capital of the Malli people

325 BCE The prince of Qin takes title of Wang (king), a claim to be the ruler of all China

324 BCE On his return to Persia, Alexander punishes officials who have acted improperly in his absence

325 BCE Alexander's army retreats through the Gedrosian desert toward Persepolis

324 BCE Alexander arranges for 90 Macedonian officers to marry the daughters of Persian and Median nobility